
THE FACELESS CHANNEL PLAYBOOK

A production system for factual short-form video: the identity lock, the five-beat script, the fact table — and the failure log from building one.

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No earnings claim. This book describes a way of working. It does not promise views, subscribers, monetization or income, and no such outcome should be inferred from anything in it.

Third-party product and platform names are used descriptively to report what was observed in production. No affiliation, sponsorship or endorsement is claimed by or for any of them.

BEFORE YOU START

READ THIS FIRST

This is the operating manual for a faceless, fact-checked, short-form video channel. It was written from the production record of one — including the two renders that were scrapped, the tool that died for seven and a half hours, and the video that shipped with a defect.

WHAT THIS IS

A complete system, in the order you need it: how to lock a visual identity so a generator can actually hold it; how to structure a sixty-second script so it survives contact with a sceptical viewer; how to verify claims before you write them; how to brief an AI video tool so your constraints reach the render; and how to keep a production record that stops you paying twice for the same lesson.

Every template in it is a working document. Take them.

WHAT THIS IS NOT

It is not a scheme, and it makes no claim about what you will earn. It does not contain a niche to copy, a done-for-you channel, or a list of prompts that produce videos while you sleep. It is not financial, legal or tax advice. And it is not a neutral survey of every way to make short video — it is one system, described in detail, with its failures attached.

WHO IT IS FOR

Someone who intends to publish at least twenty videos on one subject and wants the twentieth to be recognisably from the same publication as the first. If you plan to publish three and see how it goes, most of this will feel like overhead. It is overhead — that is the point. It is the overhead that makes volume survivable.

HOW TO USE IT

Parts Two, Three and Four before you write your first script. Part Five open beside you while you are at the tool. Part Six before you publish, Part Seven after. The appendices are the parts you will actually use every week: copy them into your own files and fill them in.

A NOTE ON THE FACTS IN THIS BOOK

Every external claim carries a source and a confidence level in Appendix F, including the ones that could not be confirmed at the primary source from the machine this was compiled on. Those are marked, not quietly rounded up. That is the same standard Part Four asks of your scripts, and it would be strange to sell you a discipline this book did not practise.

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PART ONE

THE PREMISE

Why a slower, more expensive way of making short video is now the cheaper one.

- 01 THE SLOP PROBLEM BECAME A POLICY PROBLEM
- 02 THE THREE ASSETS YOU ARE ACTUALLY BUILDING

THE SLOP PROBLEM BECAME A POLICY PROBLEM

The cost of producing a finance short fell to roughly zero. That is the market you are entering. The platform noticed before most creators did, and it responded by pricing the one input that did not get cheaper: authorship.

Anyone with a card and an afternoon can now generate a vertical explainer with a synthetic voice, stock-feel imagery and burned-in captions. Thousands of people do, daily, on the same eight topics. The supply of competent-looking short video is effectively infinite, and infinite supply destroys the value of looking competent.

In July 2025, YouTube renamed its *repetitious content* policy to *inauthentic content* and spelled out what it covers: content that is mass-produced or repetitive. The rename did not create a new prohibition — repetitive, templated uploads were already ineligible for monetization under the old wording. What it did was name the thing directly. Reporting through 2026 describes enforcement moving from video-by-video review toward channel-level assessment.

Read that as a pricing signal rather than a threat. Generated video is not penalised. The absence of a human author is. A video built from your research, carrying your position, edited to your identity, is a video with an author. The fiftieth output of a template you ran unchanged is not, and no amount of production polish converts one into the other.

**YOU ARE NOT COMPETING ON PRODUCTION.
PRODUCTION IS FREE. YOU ARE COMPETING ON THE THINGS THAT
STAYED EXPENSIVE.**

THE BAR IS ALSO RISING

While the floor was being raised on quality, it was raised on scale too. The current and announced thresholds for the YouTube Partner Program:

TIER	REQUIREMENT
Fan funding tier	500 subscribers, 3 valid public uploads in the last 90 days, and either 3,000 qualified public watch hours in 12 months or 3 million qualified Shorts views in 90 days
Ad revenue tier	1,000 subscribers, and either 4,000 qualified public watch hours in 12 months or 10 million qualified Shorts views in 90 days
From 1 Feb 2027 new applicants	1,000 subscribers, and either 8,000 watch hours or 20 million Shorts views. Channels already in the programme are reported to be grandfathered
From 1 Feb 2027 Shorts revenue share	A reported floor of 10 million qualified Shorts views per rolling 90 days to earn Shorts ad and subscription revenue, re-entered automatically on crossing back over

Thresholds and dates as recorded in Appendix F, with confidence levels. Two of YouTube's own pages were unreachable from the machine this was compiled on, so the 2027 rows rest on secondary reporting. Confirm at the platform's help centre before you plan around them — they changed twice during the period this book covers.

Watch hours and Shorts views never combine; you qualify on one or the other. For a channel that publishes only Shorts, that means the qualifying number is ten million views in ninety days — a genuinely different business from four thousand watch hours, and one worth understanding before you choose the format.

WHAT FOLLOWS FROM THIS

You cannot win this on volume, because volume is exactly what the policy is aimed at and exactly what everyone else already has. Three things stayed expensive, and they are the only durable advantages available to a channel like yours:

1. **A visual identity that is instantly recognisable** and cannot be copied carelessly, because it is specified tightly enough to survive a generator.
2. **Verified facts — including the ones that damage your own thesis.** Nothing about an automated pipeline produces this. It is manual, and it is the moat.
3. **An editorial position.** Something you think, stated plainly enough that a viewer could disagree with it.

Everything else in this book is machinery for producing those three repeatably. The system is slower than the alternative. It is slower on purpose: the slowness is located precisely where the value is.

THE THREE ASSETS YOU ARE ACTUALLY BUILDING

A channel is not a pile of videos. It is three documents that make videos, plus the videos as a by-product. If the documents do not exist outside your head, you do not have a channel — you have a habit.

ASSET ONE: THE IDENTITY DOCUMENT

One page that specifies exactly how every video looks and sounds: layer stack, palette, grade, type, captions, motion rules, ban list, hard constraints, tone. Not adjectives — rules. Chapter 7 gives the worksheet.

Here is the mechanical reason this matters more in an AI pipeline than in a traditional one. A human editor who cut your last video remembers it. A generator does not. Every render starts from nothing, and your identity reaches it through exactly one channel: the brief you write that day. If the identity lives in your head, it arrives at the render only as well as you happened to describe it that morning — and it will drift, video by video, until the channel looks like four different channels.

THE RULE

If a constraint is not written in the identity document, it will not be in the brief. If it is not in the brief, expect it to be absent from the render. Observed repeatedly, in both directions.

ASSET TWO: THE SCRIPT SYSTEM

A fixed structure — hook, define, the case, the honest counter, close — plus a fact table that every claim must pass through before it reaches narration. Part Three and Part Four.

A structure is not a formula for sameness. It is what lets you spend your judgement on the argument rather than on the shape of the argument, and it is what makes the twentieth video recognisably the work of the same publication as the first.

ASSET THREE: THE PRODUCTION RECORD

What you tried, what broke, what it cost, and what you will do differently. One file per video, written during production rather than after it.

This is the asset everyone skips and the second most valuable one you own. AI video tools fail in specific, repeatable, badly documented ways. A session that accepts your job, appears in the job list, then returns a 404 forever. A mode that preserves your script perfectly and silently discards a style constraint. A plan whose text-to-speech bills to a different credit pool than everything else, so the voice stem you assumed you had does not exist. You will hit each of these once. Without a record you will hit them twice, and the second time you will spend the same day rediscovering it.

WRITE DOWN WHAT THE WORKAROUND COSTS YOU. OTHERWISE THE WORKAROUND QUIETLY BECOMES THE DEFAULT.

WHY THESE ARE DOCUMENTS AND NOT A WORKFLOW TOOL

Keep all three as plain text files in a version-controlled folder — one directory per video. The reason is the diff. When you change the closing line of every video from a call to subscribe to something the viewer can act on, the commit records both the change and the reason. Six months later, the history explains why the channel sounds the way it does, to you and to anyone you hire.

Chapter 24 covers the file layout. It takes about fifteen minutes to set up and it is the difference between a channel and a series of attempts.

PART TWO

LOCK THE IDENTITY

A look you can describe in one page is a look a machine can hold for sixty seconds. A look you can only describe in adjectives is not a look.

- 03 IMAGERY FIRST: THE THREE-LAYER STACK
- 04 THE HERO SHOT AND THE BOOKEND
- 05 THREE COLOURS AND A BAN LIST
- 06 MOTION COMES FROM THE CAMERA
- 07 THE IDENTITY LOCK

IMAGERY FIRST: THE THREE-LAYER STACK

This is the single most important rule in the book, and it was learned the expensive way: two finished renders were scrapped over it.

The intuitive brief for a faceless explainer is “kinetic typography”. It is the wrong brief. Ask any generator for kinetic typography and it returns words floating over abstract textures — drifting gradients, particle fields, out-of-focus bokeh. It reads flat and cheap, and worse, it reads *generic*: it is exactly what every other automated finance channel looks like, because they all asked for the same thing.

The fix is to invert the stack. Photographic imagery is not decoration behind the text. It is the foundation the video is built on.

LAYER	CONTENT
Base	Cinematic photographic or rendered imagery filling the frame. The foundation of every scene — never a texture, never a wash, never something you could describe as “a background”.
Mid	Motion graphics over that imagery: diagrams, counters, charts, name-tag grids, date stamps, meters.
Top	Hero typography and burned-in word-by-word captions, current word highlighted.

Three consequences follow, and each one is a line you will need in the brief.

CAMERA MOTION APPLIES TO THE IMAGERY TOO

The common half-fix is to keep the abstract background and animate the text harder. It looks worse, because it makes the flatness legible: type moving in three dimensions over a plate that is obviously two. Push the camera through the imagery. Let the photographic layer parallax against the graphics. If the base plate is static, you have not built a stack, you have built a slide.

NAME THE SHOT, NOT THE MOOD

“Institutional, serious, financial” returns a stock loop of a skyline at dusk. A heavy official stamp striking paper, macro, cold light, returns a shot. Every beat of the script gets a specific, concrete, physical image, written into the brief as an imagery-by-beat table. This is most of the work of briefing, and it is the part that separates a video that looks made from one that looks generated.

SCRIPT BEAT	THE SHOT
A rule that locked people out is gone	Massive steel barrier gate, low angle, cold light, camera pushing in
A regulator approved it on a date	Institutional stone facade; a heavy official stamp striking paper
Three trades every five days	Macro of a mechanical turnstile counter clicking over
Your account gets restricted	Steel security shutter slamming down, padlock closing
Your exposure is tracked live	Dark server room, racks of blinking hardware, long lens
Frozen for ninety days	Frost creeping across a metal surface

Notice that none of these are illustrations of finance. They are physical objects that behave the way the idea behaves. A turnstile counts and then refuses. Frost spreads and locks. That is the whole trick.

FIELD NOTE — THE REBUILD THAT PRODUCED THIS RULE

Two videos were briefed as kinetic typography, rendered, reviewed, and killed. Both came back as text on abstract backgrounds. The narration was identical in the rebuilds; only the visual treatment changed, and the runtime did not move at all — **71.6 seconds before and after** on one of them.

The cost of the lesson was two renders and a day. The cost of the fix was three lines in the brief: name the base layer, name a shot per beat, apply the camera moves to the imagery. Those three lines are now permanent.

Keep the original renders. Not to publish — to look at next to the rebuild when you are tempted to save twenty minutes on a brief.

THE HERO SHOT AND THE BOOKEND

Sixty seconds has no room for structure a viewer can feel — except these two devices. Together they are what make a short read as a film rather than a list.

THE HERO SHOT

One shot per video: the single most tactile image in it, carrying the central idea. Not the widest shot, not the most expensive-looking. The most *physical*.

THE THESIS	THE HERO SHOT
The rule wasn't a gate, it was a seatbelt	Extreme macro: a seatbelt buckle clicking into its latch, slow motion
The moat isn't the cars, it's the plug	Extreme macro: a charging connector locking into a port, shallow focus, light on the contacts
The solution was never a better horse	An assembly line of identical chassis receding to a vanishing point

The test is simple: if a viewer saw only that frame, would they get the argument? In each case above, yes. A buckle locking is safety and restraint in one image. A connector seating is lock-in. An assembly line is replacement at scale.

How to find it: write your thesis as one sentence, underline the verb, then find the physical object that performs that verb. *Locks. Seats. Erodes. Seals. Counts and refuses.* Finance is abstract; the verbs are not.

THE BOOKEND

Open and close on the same place or object, changed by the argument. Same camera position both times — that is what makes it read as a statement rather than a coincidence.

- A steel barrier gate, closed, at the open. At the close, the same gate standing open — and the camera pulls back to reveal a sheer drop behind it. The gate is gone; the floor never existed.
- A cobbled street choked with horse traffic at the open. The same street, same angle, empty but for one motorcar, at the close.
- A castle at dawn, camera crossing the water toward it. The same castle at dusk, camera pulling back to full scale.

The bookend does three jobs at once. It gives a sixty-second piece a spine. It makes the close land as a conclusion rather than a stop. And it gives the whole video a shape a viewer can hold, which is most of what “memorable” means at this length.

BUILD NOTE

Write the bookend into the brief twice — once as the opening shot and once as the closing shot — and state explicitly that it is the *same location from the same camera position, changed*. Briefed once, generators treat the second appearance as a new scene and you lose the effect entirely.

THE MATCH-CUT CHAIN

Between the bookends, chain the video’s own objects together so each transition is a morph rather than a cut: turnstile counter to margin meter to calendar; moat ring to counter dial to charger-pin map to line chart; horse-choked avenue to assembly line to empty street.

Write the chain out as a single line in the brief. It is one sentence and it removes every plain cut from the video.

THREE COLOURS AND A BAN LIST

Near-black, white, and one red accent. Nothing else. The constraint is not minimalism for its own sake — it is the only kind of palette a generator can actually hold across a whole video.

“Rich, dynamic, premium” is not specifiable, so it drifts: scene three picks up a teal, scene six a gold, and the video stops looking like a publication. “Near-black, white, one red, imagery graded dark and desaturated” is six words, it survives restatement, and it is checkable in a single pass of the finished render.

THE GRADE IS THE PART PEOPLE FORGET

The moment you make photography the base layer, you inherit its colour. Stock and generated footage arrives warm, saturated and cheerful, and a stack of it turns an editorial explainer into a travel reel. So the instruction is explicit: **grade imagery dark and desaturated, reading toward near-black and white, and reserve the red for graphics and type.**

Red used on both footage and graphics stops being an accent. Red used only on the graphics layer becomes a signal — the viewer learns, inside two videos, that red means the number matters.

THE BAN LIST

BANNED	WHY
Neon glows, rainbow gradients, sparkles	The default decoration of every template. Instantly reads as generated.
Lens flare	Adds motion without adding meaning, and fights the grade.
Emoji and exclamation marks	Wrong register. The tone is a newsroom, not a group chat.
Subscribe animations, clickbait arrows	Buys a fraction of a follow and costs the authority that is the entire product.
Money-rain imagery, cash stacks	Attracts precisely the audience you do not want, and marks you as a pump channel to everyone else.
Real corporate logos and badges	Legal hygiene, and an identity decision — see below.
Human faces, identifiable people	The channel is faceless. Vehicles, machinery, architecture, landscape, hardware only.

WHY “NO LOGOS” IS A STYLE RULE, NOT JUST A LEGAL ONE

When a script names ten real companies, the obvious visual is a grid of their wordmarks. Use plain text name-tags instead. It keeps you clear of trademark and endorsement questions, it stops the frame turning into someone else’s brand colours — and it holds the palette. A grid of real logos is a rainbow by definition.

The same applies when a script refers to a real publication: do not render its masthead. Set the type yourself, generically.

A PALETTE YOU CAN STATE IN SIX WORDS IS A PALETTE THAT SURVIVES THE RENDER.

TYPE AND CAPTIONS

Heavy condensed sans-serif for hero words. Captions burned in, word by word, bottom third, white with a black stroke, current word highlighted — with a dark scrim behind the text wherever the plate underneath is busy. That last clause is what keeps captions readable once you have put real photography under them, and it is the constraint most often lost between brief and render. Check it on every video.

MOTION COMES FROM THE CAMERA

Every generator's default output is too static, and the instinctive fix — more effects — is the wrong one. Drama comes from camera, depth and timing. Decoration is what you add when you have not got those.

This is the spec that gets pasted into every brief. It is deliberately written as instructions rather than adjectives.

CAMERA AND DEPTH

- Treat every scene as 3D space, not a flat card. Push the camera *through* things — an archway, a gap in a chart, the space between two letters.
- Hard parallax: background, mid-ground and foreground move at visibly different speeds in every shot.
- Foreground elements streak past the lens in blur on camera moves.

TYPE

- Hero words scale past the frame edges until the camera is inside the letterforms.
- Letters arrive individually with overshoot and settle. Never a whole-word fade.
- One or two frames of white impact flash and a subtle screen shake on the biggest landings — no more.
- A light sweep rakes across heavy type after it settles.

TRANSITIONS — NO PLAIN CUTS

- Match-cut morphs chaining the video's own objects together.
- Type-as-mask reveals: a giant word wipes off and the next scene is revealed through its counters.
- Roll and whip transitions with directional motion blur.

DATA

- Numbers physically count up. They never simply appear.
- Charts draw themselves — and then structurally fail on a negative beat: crack, drop, debris.

- Make the visual metaphor fail on the downside. A wall crumbles, particle by particle, on the word *erodes*.

ENERGY AND RHYTHM

- Continuous motion in every frame. Nothing is ever fully at rest.
- Speed ramps: slow motion into a key word, snap to full speed on the cut.
- Cut or punch in every 1.2 to 1.8 seconds. No shot holds past two seconds.

THE LINE THAT SAVES THE RHYTHM

When the script runs longer than your target, say this in the brief explicitly: **a longer runtime means more cuts, not slower ones**. Left unsaid, generators stretch shots to fill the time and the whole piece goes slack. Said once, the rhythm survived a render that came in at 55.8 seconds against a 66-second estimate.

THE CONSTRAINTS THE DRAMA MUST NOT BREAK

Every escalation of energy is also an invitation to break the palette. Attach these four lines to the motion spec, every time, in the same paragraph:

- Strict three-colour palette. The drama comes from motion, not decoration.
- Captions stay readable at all times; flashes and blur never obscure them.
- No faces, no real logos, no subscribe animations.
- Analytical newsroom tone. Dramatic, not childish.

The counter-evidence beat of your script, incidentally, is the most cinematic beat you have — it is the one where something structurally fails on camera. Honest scripts get better pictures. That is not a coincidence you should waste.

THE IDENTITY LOCK

One page. Pasted into every brief, unchanged. Changing it is a deliberate act with a version number and a commit message — never a mood on a Tuesday.

Fill this in once, before your first video. Then treat it as read-only. The whole value of a locked identity is that it is boring to you long before it is familiar to your audience — you will be sick of it around video six, and your viewers will begin recognising it around video twelve. Hold it.

1 — LAYER STACK

What is the base layer, literally? What sits over it?

2 — PALETTE

Three colours maximum. Name them. Say which one is the accent and what it is reserved for.

3 — GRADE

How is photography treated so it does not read as stock?

4 — TYPE AND CAPTIONS

Typeface class, caption style, position, scrim rule.

5 — MOTION RULES

Camera, transitions, data behaviour, cut rhythm in seconds.

6 — BAN LIST

Everything that must never appear. Be specific enough to check.

7 — HARD CONSTRAINTS

Faces, logos, likeness, anything legal or structural.

8 — TONE

Three adjectives and one anti-pattern: “never a ___”.

9 — COMPLIANCE CARD

Exact wording, exact timing, on every video.

10 — FIXED SETTINGS

Style ID, voice ID, mode, orientation. Constant across the series.

A blank copy of this worksheet is in Appendix D. The completed version belongs in your repository as its own file, not inside any one video’s folder.

ON KEEPING THE VOICE CONSTANT

Whatever synthetic voice and visual style you choose, pin the identifiers and reuse them on every video. Voice is a stronger recognition cue than anything visual at this length, and it is the cheapest one to hold: it is a field in a request. Record both IDs in the production file of every video, so that a year from now you can still reproduce the series.

PART THREE

THE SCRIPT

Five beats, one of which is mandatory and almost nobody writes.

08 THE FIVE BEATS

09 THE COUNTER-EVIDENCE BEAT

10 LENGTH IS A CONSEQUENCE. CLOSE WITHOUT BAIT.

THE FIVE BEATS

Hook, define, the case, the honest counter, close. Every video. The structure is fixed so that your judgement goes into the argument instead of into the shape of the argument.

BEAT	LENGTH	ITS JOB — AND HOW IT FAILS
Hook	0–5s	State the claim flat. Fails as: a question (“Did you know...”), a throat-clear (“In this video we’ll look at...”), or a promise of a secret.
Define	5–18s	Give the concept in one sentence a non-specialist could repeat. Fails as: a synonym. “A moat is a competitive advantage” defines nothing.
The case	18–42s	Build the evidence, with the numbers, in an order where each fact makes the next one matter. Fails as: a list.
The counter	42–56s	Where the thesis is weak, with real figures. Fails as: a token hedge — “of course, nothing is guaranteed”.
Close	4–6s	Restate the thesis at its sharpest, then one thing the viewer can do. Fails as: a request for a follow.

THE DEFINE BEAT IS WHERE MOST SCRIPTS QUIETLY DIE

Compare two definitions of the same term:

“A *moat* is a competitive advantage that protects a company.” — This is a synonym dressed as a definition. A viewer learns nothing and, crucially, cannot use it.

“A *moat* is a structural advantage that stops competitors taking your profits. Not a better product — products get copied. A moat is when copying you is too expensive, or too slow, to be worth it.” — This one gives the viewer a test they can apply to the next company they hear about. That is what a definition is for.

The rule: a good define beat hands the viewer an instrument, not a label. If your definition could be swapped for the term itself without loss, rewrite it.

THE CASE BUILDS; IT DOES NOT LIST

Three facts in the wrong order are trivia. In the right order they are an argument:

```
Tesla built its own charging network.  
Then nearly every rival automaker adopted Tesla's connector  
as the North American standard.  
Now their customers pay Tesla to charge.
```

Fact one is a capital expenditure. Fact two makes fact one strategic. Fact three makes it a moat. Reorder them and the beat collapses into a list of things that happened. Before you write, put your facts in the order where each one earns the next.

WORTH NOTICING

The hook and the close are the only beats most viewers will remember, and they are the two that cost nothing to get right. Spend disproportionate time on the first sentence and the last one. Ten minutes each, minimum, after the script is otherwise finished.

THE COUNTER-EVIDENCE BEAT

The mandatory beat. It is the reason this system exists, and the single change that converts a promo into an explainer.

Somewhere between forty and fifty-five seconds in, you state — with real numbers — where your own thesis is weak. Not a disclaimer. Evidence that cuts against you.

THREE ARGUMENTS FOR IT, IN INCREASING ORDER OF SELF-INTEREST

It is honest. You are making content about money that people may act on. The disconfirming data exists whether you mention it or not.

It is better content. An explainer that admits where it is weak is more interesting than a promo, because it contains a genuine tension. Certainty is boring. A number that moves against the argument is the most engaging thing in a sixty-second video.

It is durable. A video that already contains the strongest objection cannot be dunked on with it. You have pre-empted the top comment, and you have done it in a way that makes you look like the person who did the reading.

IF YOU CANNOT FIND THE NUMBER THAT HURTS YOUR CASE, YOU HAVE NOT FINISHED RESEARCHING.

HOW TO FIND IT

After the case beat is assembled, go looking deliberately for the figure that moves the other way. Search for the quarter that was down. Check whether the trend you are describing reversed. Look for the competitor who is further ahead on the one metric you did not cite.

If you genuinely cannot find one, treat that as a signal about the thesis rather than a licence to skip the beat. Either the claim is too soft to be interesting, or you have not looked hard enough. It is almost always the second.

A WORKED EXAMPLE

The case: a company's charging standard was adopted by nearly every competitor, and its network has been valued by an analyst at as much as a hundred billion dollars.

The counter, in the video's own words:

But moats erode. Tesla's US EV share fell from nearly eighty percent in 2019 to about forty-four percent in 2025, before clawing back above fifty this year. And its energy storage revenue actually dropped year over year in early 2026.

Two things make this work. First, it is specific — three dated figures, not a mood. Second, it includes the *recovery* as well as the fall. Reporting only the decline would have been a different kind of dishonesty, and a viewer who knows the space would have caught it. The beat is not “say something negative”. It is “report the picture, including the parts that complicate your argument in both directions”.

THE ANTI-PATTERN

“Of course, no investment is without risk, so always do your own research.”

That is a disclaimer wearing the costume of analysis. It contains no information, it is true of everything, and every viewer has learned to stop listening to it. If your counter beat would be equally true of a different video on a different company, it is not a counter beat.

THE VISUAL DIVIDEND

The counter beat is also the most cinematic beat in the script — it is where the chart cracks and drops, where the wall crumbles on the word *erodes*, where the metaphor physically fails. Honest scripts get better pictures. Brief that failure explicitly, at that timecode.

LENGTH IS A CONSEQUENCE. CLOSE WITHOUT BAIT.

Runtime is an output of the argument, not a target you cut facts to hit. The close is the only line anyone repeats.

THE ARITHMETIC

Roughly 150 to 170 words of narration produces 55 to 70 seconds of finished video. Shorts accept up to three minutes — the sixty-second figure is a convention left over from an earlier limit, not a rule. Observed pairs from production:

SCRIPT	WORDS	FINISHED RUNTIME
Rule-change explainer	147	55.8s
Moat explainer	166	71.6s
Historical parallel	135	45.6s

Your word count predicts runtime better than the generator's own estimate does. One tool estimated 66 seconds for a script that rendered at 55.8. Plan from the words.

Never cut a verified fact to hit an arbitrary runtime. If you must trim, cut a data point and keep the argument — and decide in advance which data point that is, while you can still think clearly about it. On the moat script the designated trim was the energy-storage sentence: dropping it costs one figure, not the case.

THE CLOSE

No follow-bait. No “comment your favourite”. No “what do you think?” A request for a follow buys a fraction of a follow. A sentence the viewer repeats to someone else buys distribution, and it costs exactly the same number of seconds.

The pattern that works: **restate the thesis at its sharpest, then give one concrete action.**

```
The gate's open. The floor isn't.  
Check with your broker before you plan around it.
```

A moat is a position you defend. Not a trophy you keep.

The first is thesis plus action. The second is thesis alone, which is allowed when the thesis *is* the instruction — it tells the viewer how to think about the next company they look at. What is not allowed is asking for something.

FIELD NOTE — THE CLOSE THAT WAS REWRITTEN MID-FLIGHT

Two renders were stopped while still pending, before they produced output, because the close was a clickbait call to action and the rule had just been written down. Stopping a pending render costs nothing. Publishing the wrong close costs the thing the whole channel is for.

The replacement — “**Check with your broker before you plan around it**” — is also more useful to the viewer than anything the CTA was going to ask them for.

WRITING ORDER

Write the close second, immediately after the hook, and before the case. It forces you to know what the video concludes before you assemble the evidence for it, which is the only reliable defence against a script that wanders into a summary and stops.

PART FOUR

THE FACT DISCIPLINE

The part that cannot be automated, and is therefore the part that is worth something.

- 11 NEVER SCRIPT FROM MEMORY
- 12 THE FACT TABLE AND THE CONFIDENCE SCALE
- 13 WHEN THE STORY CANNOT BE SOURCED
- 14 PICK THE CLAIM YOU CAN DEFEND

NEVER SCRIPT FROM MEMORY

Verify first, draft second. Not the other way around, and not “check it afterwards” — which is a thing people sincerely intend and almost never do properly.

WHY “CHECK IT AFTERWARDS” FAILS

Once a sentence exists, it acquires momentum. You wrote it, it scans well, the beat lands on the right word. When the verification comes back slightly different — the date is the approval date, not the effective date; the figure is a range, not a point; the number is an estimate, not a price — you will find yourself softening the fact to preserve the line. Everyone does. The only defence is sequence: do the research first, build the fact table, and write the narration out of the table.

WHAT ALWAYS NEEDS RE-CHECKING

- **Regulatory dates.** Approval date, effective date and compliance deadline are three different dates and are routinely conflated.
- **Market share and revenue figures,** including their direction. “Up 27% for the year” and “down 12% for the quarter” can both be true at once.
- **Anything containing “record”, “first” or “only”.**
- **Anything you are sure about.** Confidence is a function of when you learned it, not of whether it is still true.

THE SPECIFIC RISK OF AI-ASSISTED SCRIPTING

A language model will produce a fluent, confident, precisely-formatted figure that was accurate two years ago. It does not sound like a guess, because it is not delivered as one. This is the highest-risk habit available to you, and the reason the rule is written as an absolute: **no claim enters a script that did not come from a source you looked at during this session.**

THE ASYMMETRY

Verifying a date takes about four minutes. Publishing a wrong one costs your credibility with exactly the viewers you most want: the ones who already know the subject and were deciding whether you are worth following.

No version of this trade favours skipping the search. The strategic case in Chapter 1 is that your verified facts are the moat: the fact discipline is not overhead attached to the product, it *is* the product.

THE FACT TABLE AND THE CONFIDENCE SCALE

Every script carries a table. Nothing reaches narration that is not in it. The table takes twenty minutes and does four jobs.

It forces verification to happen before drafting. It records confidence explicitly, so that a range never hardens into a point. It tells you which claims need an on-screen footnote. And when someone challenges a number in the comments six months later, it is your receipt.

THE FORMAT

CLAIM	DETAIL	CONFIDENCE
SEC approval	14 April 2026 — amendments to FINRA Rule 4210	High
Effective date	4 June 2026	High
Phase-in deadline	20 October 2027 (18 months)	High
Network valuation	Analyst estimate, “up to” \$100B; conservative case nearer \$42B	Estimate — not a market price
Manure per horse	Cited range 15–30 lbs/day; script says “about twenty”	Medium
1894 newspaper prediction	No article located; traces to a 2004 essay; attribution refuted 2018	Unsourced — see Ch. 13

THE CONFIDENCE SCALE

LEVEL	MEANS	WHAT THE SCRIPT MAY DO
High	Primary source, or several independent ones that agree	State it plainly
Medium-high	Widely reported; primary source not read directly	State it plainly; keep the source in the description
Medium	A single secondary source, or a range you are summarising	Hedge in the wording: “about”, “over”, “roughly”
Estimate	An analyst projection or model output	Say whose estimate it is, on screen. Never speak it as a price
Unsourced	Cannot be traced to any original	Do not assert it. Chapter 13 shows the alternative

THE ESTIMATE RULE, IN THREE LAYERS

An analyst’s valuation of a business unit is not a market price, and treating one as the other is the most common dishonesty in finance video — usually unintentional. The handling that works puts the same correction at three levels of depth:

- **In the narration:** “Morgan Stanley has valued that network as high as a hundred billion dollars.” — *has valued, as high as.*
- **On screen:** a small footnote under the figure reading “Morgan Stanley est.”
- **In the pinned comment:** the full range, including the conservative case at roughly \$42 billion.

A viewer who watches casually gets a hedged sentence. A viewer who is paying attention gets the attribution. A viewer who came to argue gets the range, and finds you already put it there.

ROUND HONESTLY

“Over a hundred thousand horses” is safe when the figure is about 128,000. “About twenty pounds a day” is honest when the cited range is 15 to 30. Rounding toward the claim you want is where credibility leaks out of a script one word at a time — always round toward the weaker version of your own argument.

WHEN THE STORY CANNOT BE SOURCED

The best anecdotes in finance are usually the least sourced. This is the most useful technique in the book, and it turns a liability into the strongest beat in the video.

THE CASE

A famous story: in 1894, a London newspaper predicted that within fifty years every street in the city would be buried under nine feet of horse manure. It is a perfect hook — vivid, absurd, and it sets up the point that the solution to a crisis is rarely a better version of the thing causing it.

No such article has ever been found. The quote, the fifty-year figure and the collapsed-conference detail all trace to a single essay from 2004, and The Times refuted the attribution in 2018.

THREE OPTIONS

Drop it. Safe, and you lose the best hook available on the subject.

Assert it anyway. Most channels do. It is a lie, and it hands the comment section a reason to dismiss everything else you said.

Keep it and source it honestly. This is the one.

THE FIX

You've heard this one. Eighteen ninety-four. A London newspaper predicts that within fifty years, every street in the city will be buried under nine feet of horse manure.

No one has ever found that article. But the crisis underneath it was real.

The hook survives verbatim, reframed as a *familiar claim* rather than a reported fact. The correction takes five seconds. And everything after it is documented: New York alone had well over a hundred thousand horses; each produced roughly twenty pounds a day; fifteen million Model Ts had been built by 1927; cars outnumbered horses in New York by 1912.

Because the audience now knows you check things, the documented material lands *harder*. The correction is not a cost. It is the beat that earns the rest.

THE THREE-LAYER HANDLING AGAIN

Script: the correction, spoken, immediately after the hook. **On screen:** a small footnote at that timecode — “Quote unsourced — attribution refuted, 2018.” **Pinned comment:** “Before anyone posts it: yes, the quote can’t be sourced — that’s said in the video. The horses, the tonnage and the speed of the switch are all real.”

THE GENERAL RULE

An honest correction, placed early, is a hook rather than a weakness. It costs one sentence of runtime and it buys the one thing that cannot be generated at scale: the viewer’s belief that the numbers in the next forty seconds were checked by somebody.

Apply it to any widely-repeated story before you use it. The founder anecdote, the famous quote, the statistic that appears in every deck. A surprising number of them trace to one uncited blog post, and each one is an opportunity in disguise.

PICK THE CLAIM YOU CAN DEFEND

Choosing your angle is a fact-discipline decision before it is a creative one. Two videos can make the same argument, and only one of them stays true.

THE CASE

Asked to explain a company's competitive moat, the obvious angle was its self-driving software. It is the claim the company itself emphasises and the one most commentators reach for.

It is also the least verifiable. The fleet-mileage figures come from company statements and are then recycled through aggregators until they acquire the appearance of independent data. And on the metric that would actually settle it — deployed driverless operation — a competitor was further ahead.

The angle that was used instead: the charging network. Nearly every rival automaker adopted the company's connector as the North American standard. That fact is independently verifiable from the rivals' own announcements.

PREFER THE CLAIM EVIDENCED BY A PARTY WITH AN INCENTIVE TO SAY THE OPPOSITE.

A competitor adopting your standard is objective evidence of an advantage in a way that a self-reported number can never be. They had every reason not to, and they did it anyway. There is no stronger evidence available in business journalism, and it is usually sitting in a press release nobody read.

TWO HEURISTICS

One: prefer facts with a date and a document behind them. A rule change has an approval date, an effective date and a published notice. A production figure has a filing. A trend has a dataset. If your central claim has none of these, you are not making an explainer, you are making a take.

Two: prefer the claim you could still defend if the company went quiet tomorrow. Anything that depends on continued disclosure from an interested party is a claim with an expiry date attached.

WHAT IT COSTS

Sometimes the more exciting angle. The self-driving story is a better thumbnail than a connector, and you should be honest with yourself that you are trading some reach for durability.

What it buys is a video that is still correct in two years, from a channel whose archive does not quietly become a liability. For a channel whose entire strategic position is “the facts here are checked”, that is not a close call — but it is a real trade, and it should be made deliberately and written into the script file as a note, so that the reasoning survives you.

PART FIVE

PRODUCTION

Your identity reaches the finished video through exactly one channel. This is how to write it, and what to do when the tool stops working.

- 15 THE BRIEF IS THE PRODUCT
- 16 APPROVAL IS THE MECHANISM
- 17 WHEN THE TOOL BREAKS: A TRIAGE PROTOCOL
- 18 COMPLETE IS NOT VERIFIED
- 19 CREDITS ARE A PRODUCTION CONSTRAINT

THE BRIEF IS THE PRODUCT

Everything in Parts Two, Three and Four exists only as far as it survives into the brief. The brief is not paperwork preceding the work. It is the work.

THE EIGHT BLOCKS

BLOCK	WHAT IT MUST CONTAIN
Format and constraint	Duration, aspect ratio, and the defining negative: no avatar, no presenter, no human face anywhere. Voiceover only.
The script, verbatim	The narration, with an explicit instruction not to alter it.
Layer stack	Base, mid, top — named as layers, in order.
Imagery by beat	A concrete shot for every beat. The hero shot marked. The bookend named at both ends.
Motion	The spec from Chapter 6, including the cut rhythm in seconds.
Look	Palette, grade, caption legibility rule.
Hard constraints	Faces, logos, ban list, compliance card and its timing.
Tone	Three adjectives and the anti-pattern.

The complete copy-paste template is Appendix C.

WRITE THE SCRIPT INSTRUCTION AS A COMMAND

```
Use this narration script VERBATIM — do not rewrite, shorten,
or add to it:
"[SCRIPT]"
```

Without that line, generators paraphrase. They shorten a clause, smooth a number, turn “about twenty pounds” into “twenty pounds”. The moment the audio stops matching your fact table, every hour you spent in Part Four is gone — and you will not notice, because you know what the script was supposed to say.

CHECK THIS ON EVERY RENDER

Read the narration back against the script, scene by scene, from whatever transcript or scene data the tool exposes. On one production the verbatim instruction held across all ten scenes — which is only worth knowing because it was checked rather than assumed.

NAME SHOTS, NOT MOODS

Said in Chapter 3, repeated here because it is the single highest-leverage habit in briefing. Mood adjectives produce stock footage. Physical nouns and verbs produce shots. Write the imagery table before you write anything else in the brief; if a beat resists having a concrete shot, that beat is probably too abstract to be in the script.

SETTINGS ARE PART OF THE IDENTITY

Visual style, voice, mode and orientation stay constant across every video in the series, and their identifiers are recorded in each video's production file. This is what makes a channel read as one publication rather than a playlist. It costs nothing to hold and it is very expensive to reconstruct after the fact, when a tool has retired the exact voice you used and you have no note of which one it was.

FIELD NOTE — BRAND KITS MAY NOT PERSIST

On at least one platform, the agent builds an on-brand kit *per session* and does not save it to the workspace: listing the account's brand kits afterwards shows only the vendor's demo kit. There is no reusable identifier to pin.

The practical consequence: **you cannot store your identity in the tool.** It has to be restated, in full, in every brief. The template is the mechanism. Check whether this is true of your own stack before you rely on a saved preset.

APPROVAL IS THE MECHANISM

Most video generators offer two paths: one that pauses to show you a plan and accepts revisions, and one that takes your prompt and returns a finished file. Take the slow one, for a reason that is not the obvious one.

The obvious reason is that you get to fix mistakes. The real reason is better: the approval step is a second place to say the constraints. Restating the grade, the bookend and the hero shot at the moment the plan is presented is what makes them survive generation. A constraint stated once is a suggestion. A constraint stated at the brief and again at approval is a rule.

THE FEWER CHANCES YOU GET TO RESTATE A CONSTRAINT, THE MORE LIKELY IT IS ABSENT FROM THE OUTPUT.

WHAT FIRE-AND-FORGET COSTS, MEASURED

On one production the revisable mode was failing (Chapter 17), so the fallback was used. The result was instructive rather than catastrophic:

CHECK	RESULT
Narration verbatim across all ten scenes	Pass
Series voice held	Pass
9:16 portrait, 1080p	Pass
Burned-in captions — required by house style	Fail — disabled
Imagery-first base layer	Unknown

The script came through perfectly. A style constraint was silently dropped. That is the characteristic failure mode of the fast path: it protects the thing you gave it literally, and it quietly loses the things you described.

HOW TO USE THE APPROVAL STEP WELL

1. Read the plan for *absences*, not errors. What did it not mention? The grade, the bookend, the footnote, and the cut rhythm are the four most commonly silently dropped.
2. Reply with the constraints restated in full sentences, not “yes but darker”.

3. Restate the negative constraints too. “No human faces” is worth repeating at approval even when nothing in the plan suggests a face.
4. Then approve. Do not renegotiate the script at this point — the script was settled in Part Three and reopening it here is how videos die.

REVISABLE SESSIONS ARE ALSO YOUR REVISION PATH

A session you can reply to lets you fix a defect without paying for a full rebuild. Record the session URL in the production file alongside the video ID; a render you can revise in a week is worth substantially more than one you cannot.

WHEN THE TOOL BREAKS: A TRIAGE PROTOCOL

AI video tools fail in ways that look like your fault. Having a protocol turns a lost day into twenty minutes and a note in the production file.

THE INCIDENT

Two jobs were submitted in the ordinary way. Both were accepted. Both appeared in the account's session list. Both then returned 404 on every attempt to read their status, and produced no video at all. One stayed dead for more than seven and a half hours. Same tool, same parameters that had worked earlier the same day.

THE PROTOCOL

#	RULE OUT	HOW
1	Your account	Check the credit balance and plan entitlements. A surprising share of “broken” tools are exhausted quotas.
2	The service	Call the same endpoint with an older, known-good identifier. If it returns full detail, the endpoint is healthy and the problem is your new object — not the API and not your code.
3	The request	Compare against a request that worked earlier. Same tool, same parameters, same shape.
4	Then switch paths	Use the fallback — and write down what the fallback costs you.

In the incident above, step 1 showed 330 credits remaining, step 2 returned full detail for an older session, and step 3 found no difference. That triangulation is what licensed the conclusion “the service is degraded for new objects of this type” rather than the much more expensive conclusion “I am doing something wrong”, which would have produced another four hours of rewriting a request that was already correct.

STEP 4 IS THE ONE EVERYONE SKIPS

The fallback mode returned a real job identifier immediately and was trackable normally. It worked. It also skipped the blueprint approval step, which — per Chapter 16 — is the mechanism that keeps constraints alive. That cost was recorded in the production file at the time, along with the instruction *prefer the primary mode once it recovers*.

WHY WRITING DOWN THE COST MATTERS

An undocumented workaround becomes the default. It is faster, it worked once, and nobody remembers what it traded away. Three months later the channel's quality has drifted and the cause is invisible because it was never written down. One line in the production file prevents this: **what I did instead, and what it cost.**

GENERALISE IT

Account, then service, then request, then fallback-with-a-recorded-cost. This is a protocol for any AI tool in any pipeline, and it is worth pinning somewhere you will see it at the moment things go wrong — which is exactly the moment nobody reaches for a checklist.

FIELD NOTE — THE JOB THAT PRODUCED NOTHING

One session had already been given a full brief before the failure was understood. It sat dead for 7.5 hours and no video from it ever appeared in the account. Its directory was deleted and the research folded into the rebuild.

Delete the artefacts of dead runs. Keep the research. A repository full of hopeful empty folders is how a production record stops being trustworthy.

COMPLETE IS NOT VERIFIED

A render that finished is not a render you have seen. Keeping those two states separate, in writing, is the difference between a production record and a wish list.

In the production this book is drawn from, the constraint was absolute: network policy blocked the vendor's media hosts outright, so no finished file could be downloaded or watched from the machine that made it. Every render was logged as **complete, not verified**.

That sounds like a disadvantage. It produced the most useful habit in the whole system, because it forced the verification to become a written artefact rather than a feeling.

THE THREE STATES

STATE	MEANS
Pass	Confirmed, and the evidence is named — watched, or read from structured data.
Fail	Confirmed absent or wrong. Fix it before publishing.
Unknown	Could not be determined by the means available. Not the same as Fail.

WHAT METADATA CAN TELL YOU

More than you would expect. On one render, the scene data reported that captions were disabled — a direct violation of house style, caught without watching a single frame. Better still, no re-render was needed: the platform had produced a separate captioned cut, and publishing that one fixed the defect for free.

Check from structured data wherever you can: narration text per scene, voice identifier, aspect ratio and resolution, caption flags, scene count and durations.

WHAT METADATA CANNOT TELL YOU

On the same render, every scene reported a white background with a single element of type *motion graphics*. Read literally, that is a white video — which would fail both the imagery-first rule and the palette.

But that API described only some element types in full; a full-frame background plate carried as a motion-graphics element appears as nothing but an identifier and a type. So a plate could be present and invisible to the query. The honest verdict was **Unknown**, not Fail — and that distinction saved a re-render that might have been chasing a phantom.

RECORD WHAT YOU COULD NOT CHECK AS CAREFULLY AS WHAT YOU COULD.

THE HANDOFF CHECKLIST

When you cannot watch a render yourself, write the checklist for whoever can — a collaborator, a client, or you on a different device. Keep it to things that are checkable in one viewing, in order of how expensive they are to fix:

- ☐ No human faces or identifiable people anywhere.
- ☐ Imagery is genuinely the base layer — real plates under the graphics, not abstract texture. Name the specific shots that must be present.
- ☐ Palette held: near-black, white, one red. No neon, gradients or sparkles that crept in under an instruction to be “more dramatic”.
- ☐ Captions present, burned in, and readable through flashes, blur and shake.
- ☐ No real corporate logos or badges; name-tags are plain text.
- ☐ Required footnotes present at the right timecodes.
- ☐ Compliance card visible in the first four seconds.
- ☐ The close is the scripted close, with no subscribe or follow animation.
- ☐ Cut rhythm: no shot holding past about two seconds.
- ☐ Hero shot present; bookend returns at the close from the same camera position.

Any item failing goes back through the revisable session rather than into a rebuild.

CREDITS ARE A PRODUCTION CONSTRAINT

Treat generation credits the way a film production treats stock. They are finite, they are consumed by mistakes, and the cheapest shot is the one you did not have to take twice.

A REAL CONSTRAINT LOG

CONSTRAINT HIT	CONSEQUENCE FOR THE WORK
B-roll generator at zero credits	No custom footage at all. The shots worth buying were identified and written down for when it is topped up.
Thumbnail tool at ~1 credit, generation costs 22	No generated thumbnail. Fallback: the video tool's own auto-generated thumbnail.
Text-to-speech billed to a different credit pool than video	No detached voice stem. Narration is baked into the render.

The third one is the dangerous one, and it is worth stating plainly because it is easy to assume otherwise: **if you cannot generate speech separately, you have no audio stem, and the render is the master.** You cannot recut it in an editor, retime a beat, or swap a clause. Decide before you render whether you need a stem — and if you do, confirm that your plan actually includes it rather than assuming that a video tool with a voice must expose one.

THREE HABITS THAT SAVE CREDITS

Stop renders you already know are wrong. Two were stopped while still pending, before producing output, when the closing line was rewritten. A stopped pending job costs nothing; a finished one you will not publish costs a full render.

Get the brief right rather than iterating cheaply. With AI video there is no cheap iteration — every revision is a render. Twenty more minutes on the brief is the least expensive thing on the menu.

Note the credit balance and its reset date in every production file. It turns “I think we’re running low” into a number you can plan a month around.

KEEP A STANDING CONSTRAINTS LIST

Maintain one list of environment constraints that applies across all videos — what is blocked, what is exhausted, which capability your plan does not include. Read it before you plan a video, not after you have designed one around a tool you cannot use. It stops you rediscovering the same wall monthly, which is the most demoralising way to lose a morning.

PART SIX

PUBLISH

Packaging, the thumbnail score trap, the compliance you cannot skip, and a sober look at what monetization actually requires.

- 20** PACKAGING: TITLES, DESCRIPTION, PINNED COMMENT
- 21** THUMBNAILS AND THE SCORE TRAP
- 22** COMPLIANCE YOU CANNOT SKIP
- 23** WHAT MONETIZATION ACTUALLY REQUIRES

PACKAGING: TITLES, DESCRIPTION, PINNED COMMENT

Four small artefacts, each with a distinct job. Write all of them into the script file before the video renders, so that packaging is a decision rather than something you improvise at upload.

TITLES: WRITE THREE, ALL TRUE

1. The \$25,000 Day Trading Rule Just Died
2. They Removed The PDT Rule. Read The Fine Print.
3. Day Trading With \$2,000 Is Now Legal (Here's The Catch)

Every one of those is accurate. Writing three forces you past the first phrasing, which is almost never the best one, and it gives you something to swap to if a video underperforms.

The selection test for this kind of channel is not “which is most clickable” but **which would a sceptic click** — someone who already knows the subject and is deciding whether you are serious. “Read the fine print” and “here’s the catch” both promise the thing the channel actually delivers: the part other coverage leaves out. Promise the counter-evidence beat. It is your differentiator, and unlike a clickbait promise, you can keep it.

RETITLE AT UPLOAD

Generators auto-title renders off-script, and the result is usually a flattened description of the content. Ignore it. Use the title from your own packaging block — and keep the tool’s title out of the file name too, or it will propagate.

THE DESCRIPTION CARRIES THE SOURCES

A moat is a structural advantage that keeps competitors from taking your profits. Tesla's clearest one isn't the vehicles — it's that nearly every rival automaker adopted Tesla's charging connector as the North American standard. Also covered: where that moat has been eroding.

Sources: automaker standard-adoption announcements; EV share data; quarterly filings. Not financial advice. Educational only.

Two paragraphs: what the video argues, then where it came from. Listing sources costs thirty seconds and is one of the few visible signals that separates you from a templated channel — templated channels never have them, because there is nothing to list.

THE PINNED COMMENT IS A CORRECTION CHANNEL

Use it for three things, in this order of value:

- **The caveat that did not fit the runtime.** “Brokers have until October 2027 to implement — check whether yours has actually turned it on before you plan around it.”
- **The objection you know is coming.** “Before anyone posts it: yes, the quote can’t be sourced — that’s said in the video.”
- **The precision an estimate needs.** “The \$100B figure is an analyst estimate for the network, not a market price — a more conservative scenario put it nearer \$42B. Treat it as a range.”

Each of these converts a potential top comment into a pinned one written by you. It is the cheapest reputational work available on the platform.

HASHTAGS

Five, specific to the subject rather than to the genre. They are the least important artefact on this page; write them last and do not agonise.

THUMBNAILS AND THE SCORE TRAP

Thumbnail scoring tools penalise low saturation and reward vibrancy. If your identity is a dark, desaturated, three-colour palette, the score will fight you on every single video. Do not let it win.

Understand what the score is measuring. It is a model of what performs on average, trained on what already exists. Your entire strategic position — see Chapter 1 — is that you are deliberately not the average. Optimising to that score converts your channel into the thing the score was trained on, which is the one outcome you cannot afford.

THE SCORE OPTIMISES FOR THE AVERAGE THUMBNAIL. YOUR WHOLE PLAN IS TO NOT BE IT.

WHEN TO LISTEN TO IT ANYWAY

Scoring tools are genuinely useful on the mechanical questions, and you should take those notes seriously:

- **Legibility at small size.** Real. Check it at thumbnail scale, on a phone.
- **Subject size and clarity.** Real. One subject, large.
- **Text length.** Real. Three or four words maximum.
- **Contrast.** Real — and note that a near-black and white palette with one red accent is *high* contrast. You can satisfy this one without moving.
- **Saturation and vibrancy.** Ignore. This is the identity trade, and it is the whole of the disagreement.

CHEAP THUMBNAILS WHEN THE CREDITS ARE GONE

Video generators frequently produce a thumbnail alongside the plan, at no extra cost. It may be session-internal — visible on the session page but not retrievable through the API — which is inconvenient but not disqualifying: screenshot it, or rebuild it from the hero shot.

Better still, design the thumbnail into the script file from the start. Your hero shot is almost always the right frame: it is the most tactile image in the video and it already carries the thesis. A macro of a buckle locking with three words of condensed type over it will outperform

anything a generator improvises, and it reinforces the identity every time it appears in a feed.

THE HONEST VERSION OF THIS ADVICE

You are trading some click-through for recognisability and authority. That is a real cost, not a free lunch, and it is only the right trade if you are actually going to publish enough videos for recognisability to compound. If you plan to publish five, take the vibrant thumbnail.

COMPLIANCE YOU CANNOT SKIP

Four things, none of them optional, none of them expensive. This chapter is a production checklist, not legal advice — rules differ by jurisdiction and change often, and you should confirm the current versions for yourself.

ONE — THE CARD, IN THE FIRST FOUR SECONDS

“Educational only. Not financial advice.” On screen, small but legible, from 0:00 to 0:04 of every video. Not in the description instead. Not at the end. In the first four seconds, where a viewer who watches nothing else still sees it.

Write it into the identity lock, the brief and the pre-publish checklist, because it is exactly the kind of constraint that goes missing when a generator is being creative with the opening.

TWO — DISCLOSE SYNTHETIC CONTENT WHERE IT IS REALISTIC

Platforms require creators to disclose realistic altered or synthetic content — material a viewer could reasonably mistake for a real person, place or event. Synthetic or cloned voices depicting a real person, digitally manipulated footage of someone saying something they did not say, and fabricated real-world events are the clear cases. Production assistance — colour work, stylisation, clearly unrealistic or animated material — generally is not.

A faceless channel that bans real people, real logos and real mastheads sits mostly on the light side of that line. That is a happy consequence of the style rules rather than a reason to stop thinking about it. Disclose when in doubt: the toggle costs nothing, and repeated non-disclosure is enforced with content removal and monetization penalties.

THREE — NO REAL LOGOS, BADGES OR MASTHEADS

Plain text name-tags, always. This keeps you clear of trademark and implied-endorsement problems, and — per Chapter 5 — it holds the palette at the same time. When a script names a real publication, set the type generically rather than reproducing its masthead.

FOUR — NO IDENTIFIABLE PEOPLE

No faces, no recognisable individuals, including in background footage. Frame people out or use distant silhouettes. This is a likeness question as much as a style one, and generated footage makes it easier to get wrong than real footage does — the person in the frame may resemble

someone without anyone having decided that they should.

WHERE THIS IS GENUINELY NOT ENOUGH

If you move from explaining public information to recommending specific securities, to managing anyone's money, or to accepting payment for coverage, you are in a different regulatory category and this chapter stops being sufficient. Sponsorships and affiliate arrangements carry their own disclosure obligations. Take proper advice before you cross any of those lines.

WHAT MONETIZATION ACTUALLY REQUIRES

Read this before you build a plan that depends on platform revenue. The numbers are larger than most people assume, and they moved twice in the period this book covers.

MILESTONE	REQUIREMENT
Fan funding tier	500 subscribers · 3 valid public uploads in 90 days · 3,000 watch hours in 12 months <i>or</i> 3 million Shorts views in 90 days
Ad revenue tier	1,000 subscribers · 4,000 watch hours in 12 months <i>or</i> 10 million Shorts views in 90 days
New applicants from 1 Feb 2027	1,000 subscribers · 8,000 watch hours <i>or</i> 20 million Shorts views. Existing members reported as grandfathered
Shorts revenue share from 1 Feb 2027	A reported floor of 10 million qualified Shorts views per rolling 90 days; falling below pauses Shorts revenue, crossing back restores it automatically
Always	No active Community Guidelines strikes. Watch hours and Shorts views never combine — you qualify on one or the other

See Appendix F for sources, dates and confidence. The 2027 rows rest on secondary reporting because the primary pages were unreachable from the machine this was compiled on. Confirm before planning.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR A SHORTS-FIRST CHANNEL

Ten million qualified Shorts views in ninety days is the bar, and it is a different business from four thousand watch hours. Watch hours from Shorts in the Shorts feed do not count toward the watch-hour route, so a pure Shorts channel cannot creep in through the other door.

The planning consequence is straightforward, and it is better to accept it at the start than to discover it at month eight:

DO NOT BUILD A BUSINESS MODEL THAT REQUIRES SHORTS AD REVENUE EARLY.

Shorts are a distribution and credibility engine. They are extraordinarily good at putting a specific, verifiable, well-made argument in front of people who have never heard of you, and extraordinarily bad at paying for themselves in the first year.

WHERE THE REVENUE ACTUALLY IS, EARLIER

Things you own, sold to an audience that trusts you because of how the videos are made: a written product, a list, a paid newsletter, a sponsorship you can accept without compromising the thing that made you worth sponsoring. Every one of those depends on the fact discipline in Part Four. That is not a coincidence — the discipline is what converts attention into credibility, and credibility is the only part of this that can be sold.

This book makes no claim about what you will earn. It does not know your subject, your publishing rate, or your luck, and anyone who tells you a number without knowing those is selling you something. What it can tell you is which of your assets is durable, and the answer is not the videos.

PART SEVEN

THE SYSTEM

The files, one video walked end to end, and the checklist that runs before anything is published.

- 24 REPO AS RECORD
- 25 TEARDOWN: ONE SHORT, END TO END
- 26 THE PRE-PUBLISH CHECKLIST

REPO AS RECORD

One directory per video. Two files in it. Fifteen minutes to set up, and it is the difference between a channel and a series of attempts.

```
channel/  
  IDENTITY.md           – the locked identity. One file, versioned.  
  CONSTRAINTS.md       – standing environment limits across all videos.  
  moat-short/  
    SCRIPT.md           – narration, fact table, imagery, packaging  
    PRODUCTION.md       – IDs, settings, verification, constraints hit  
  pdt-short/  
    SCRIPT.md  
    PRODUCTION.md  
    thumbnail.png
```

WHAT GOES IN THE SCRIPT FILE

- Runtime target, format, and the beat-by-beat narration with timecodes
- The fact table, with confidence levels and any required on-screen footnotes
- A note on *why this angle* — the reasoning from Chapter 14
- Imagery by beat, hero shot marked, bookend named, match-cut chain
- Packaging: three titles, description, hashtags, pinned comment
- The compliance line

WHAT GOES IN THE PRODUCTION FILE

- The finished video's identifier and its revisable session URL
- Style, voice, mode and orientation — the identifiers, not the names
- Duration and format as actually rendered
- The verification checklist, with *Pass / Fail / Unknown* per item and the evidence for each
- Constraints hit, and what each one cost
- Superseded renders, with one line on why they were superseded

WHY VERSION CONTROL RATHER THAN A FOLDER OF DOCUMENTS

The diff. When you change the close of every video from a call to subscribe to something the viewer can act on, the commit carries both the change and the reason. Six months on, the history explains why the channel sounds the way it does — to you, to a collaborator, and to anyone you eventually hire to do this without you.

A worked example from the record this book is drawn from, in commit order: *add the short · rewrite close: drop clickbait CTA for an actionable one · add imagery layer spec: photography as the base, not abstract backgrounds · lock the channel style · record render, links and verification checklist*. That sequence is the channel's entire design history, and it cost nothing to keep.

THE RULE THAT KEEPS IT ALIVE

Write the production file *during* production, not after it. The constraint you hit at eleven at night — the credit pool that turned out to be separate, the mode that 404s — is the one you will have rationalised into vagueness by the morning.

KEEP THE SUPERSEDED RENDERS

Not to publish. To compare. A scrapped version next to its rebuild is the most persuasive argument available for why the brief takes twenty more minutes, and it is the only one that still works on you when you are tired.

TEARDOWN: ONE SHORT, END TO END

Every rule in this book, applied to a single fifty-six-second video, in the order it happened.

1 — THE TRIGGER

A regulatory change with a hard date. These are the best subjects available to a factual channel: they have documents, they have dates, they affect the viewer directly, and most coverage of them is wrong in a way you can fix.

2 — VERIFICATION, BEFORE A WORD WAS WRITTEN

CLAIM	DETAIL
SEC approval	14 April 2026 — amendments to FINRA Rule 4210
Effective	4 June 2026
Eliminated	The “pattern day trader” designation, day-trade counting, and the \$25,000 minimum equity requirement
Replacement	An intraday margin standard keyed to real-time exposure
Phase-in	18 months for broker systems, ending 20 October 2027
\$2,000	The existing minimum to open a margin account — unchanged, and <i>not</i> a new day-trading floor

That last row is the one that made the video worth making. Most coverage reported “you can now day trade with \$2,000”, which conflates a long-standing account minimum with a permission. Getting it right was four minutes of reading.

3 — THE ANGLE

Not “day trading is free now”. The thesis: **the gate is gone, but the floor never existed**. A restriction was removed and a different, live, less visible one replaced it. That is a claim with documents behind it, and it is the opposite of the consensus take.

4 — THE FIVE BEATS, AS WRITTEN

```
HOOK 0:00 The twenty-five thousand dollar rule that locked you out
of day trading is dead.

DEFINE June 4th, 2026. FINRA killed the Pattern Day Trader rule.
The label, the trade counting, the twenty-five K minimum –
all of it, gone.

CASE For twenty-five years, under 25K meant three day trades
every five days. Take a fourth? Your account got restricted
for ninety days. Now a two thousand dollar margin account
can trade intraday with no counter.

COUNTER But that rule wasn't just a gate. It was a seatbelt.
It's replaced by an intraday margin standard. Your broker
tracks your real exposure live, all day. Run a deficit, you
get five business days to cover it – miss that, and you're
frozen for ninety days anyway.
And brokers have until October 2027 to switch on.
Yours might not have.

CLOSE The gate's open. The floor isn't.
Check with your broker before you plan around it.
```

147 words. The counter beat runs long deliberately — it carries two separate pieces of disconfirming evidence, the replacement rule and the phase-in, and it is the reason the video exists.

5 — HERO SHOT AND BOOKEND

Hero: extreme macro of a seatbelt buckle clicking into its latch, slow motion, on the line *“It was a seatbelt.”*

Bookend: a massive steel barrier gate. Closed, low angle, camera pushing in at the open. At the close, the same gate standing open — and the camera pulls back to reveal a sheer drop behind it.

Match-cut chain: turnstile counter → margin meter → calendar.

Impact words: DEAD · SEATBELT · THE FLOOR ISN'T.

6 — THE BRIEF AND THE RENDER

House brief template, revisable mode, series style and voice, portrait. The tool estimated 66 seconds for the verbatim script and was told explicitly that a longer runtime meant *more cuts, not slower ones*. It rendered at **55.8 seconds**, with the cut rhythm intact.

7 — WHAT WENT WRONG

The first version was briefed before the imagery rule existed and came back as typography on abstract backgrounds. It was scrapped and rebuilt with the three-layer stack. Both versions are kept; only the rebuild was published.

The finished file could not be watched from the production machine — the vendor’s media hosts were blocked — so it was logged **complete, not verified**, with a nine-point checklist attached for first viewing.

8 — PACKAGING

Three titles written, the “read the fine print” variant selected. Description carrying the summary, the sources and the disclaimer. Pinned comment holding the caveat that did not fit the runtime: *brokers have until October 2027 to implement — check whether yours has actually turned it on.*

THE SCOREBOARD

Roughly a day of work for fifty-six seconds of video: about two hours of verification, two hours of scripting, an hour of briefing, the render, the rebuild after the first attempt was scrapped, and the packaging.

What it bought: a video that is still correct, that contains its own strongest objection, that is visibly from the same publication as every other video on the channel, and that can be defended line by line against anyone who arrives to argue. **At twenty videos, that is a channel. At twenty templated ones, it is an inventory.**

THE PRE-PUBLISH CHECKLIST

Run it in order, every time. It takes about ten minutes and it is the last place any of this can be saved.

FACTS

- ☐ Every claim in the narration appears in the fact table, with a confidence level.
- ☐ No claim came from memory. Each was checked against a source during this production.
- ☐ Estimates are spoken as estimates, attributed on screen, and ranged in the pinned comment.
- ☐ Any unsourced story is flagged in the script itself, not quietly asserted.
- ☐ Rounding runs toward the weaker version of your own argument.

SCRIPT

- ☐ All five beats present, and the counter-evidence beat carries real figures — not a disclaimer.
- ☐ The define beat hands the viewer an instrument, not a synonym.
- ☐ The close restates the thesis and asks for nothing.
- ☐ Narration in the render matches the script word for word.

IDENTITY

- ☐ Imagery is genuinely the base layer. Hero shot present. Bookend returns from the same camera position.
- ☐ Palette held — near-black, white, one red. Nothing from the ban list appeared.
- ☐ Captions burned in and readable over every plate.
- ☐ No shot holds past about two seconds.
- ☐ Style and voice identifiers match the rest of the series.

COMPLIANCE

- ☐ “Educational only. Not financial advice.” on screen in the first four seconds.
- ☐ No human faces or identifiable people anywhere.
- ☐ No real logos, badges or mastheads — plain text name-tags only.
- ☐ Synthetic-content disclosure considered, and applied if the material is realistic.

PUBLISH

- ☐ Title taken from your packaging block, not from the generator.
- ☐ Description carries the summary, the sources and the disclaimer.
- ☐ Pinned comment ready before upload.
- ☐ Production file updated: IDs, settings, verification states with evidence, constraints hit.

IF YOU ONLY EVER RUN FOUR OF THESE

The fact table is complete. The counter-evidence beat is real. The compliance card is in the first four seconds. The narration matches the script. Those four protect you from the failures that are expensive to undo; everything else on this page protects quality, which you can fix next time.

APPENDICES

THE WORKING DOCUMENTS

Copy these into your own repository. They are the parts of this book you will touch every week.

- A** SCRIPT FILE TEMPLATE
- B** PRODUCTION FILE TEMPLATE
- C** THE BRIEF TEMPLATE
- D** IDENTITY LOCK WORKSHEET
- E** CONFIDENCE SCALE — QUICK CARD
- F** SOURCES AND VERIFICATION LOG
- G** LICENCE

APPENDIX A

SCRIPT FILE TEMPLATE

Save as `SCRIPT.md` in the video's directory.

```
# [TITLE]

Runtime target: [__]s · Format: 9:16 · Style: [series name]

### VO SCRIPT ([__] words)

[0:00-0:05] HOOK
> [The claim, stated flat.]

[0:05-0:18] DEFINE
> [One sentence a non-specialist could repeat. An instrument, not a synonym.]

[0:18-0:42] THE CASE
> [Facts in the order where each one earns the next.]

[0:42-0:56] THE HONEST COUNTER
> [Real figures that cut against the thesis. Never a disclaimer.]

[0:56-1:00] CLOSE
> [Thesis at its sharpest. One action. Ask for nothing.]

### FACT BASE

| Claim | Detail | Confidence |
|---|---|---|
| | | |

On-screen footnotes required:
- [timecode] — [exact wording]

### WHY THIS ANGLE

[Which claim you chose to build on and why it is the defensible one.
What you passed over, and what that cost.]

### IMAGERY

Hero shot: [the most tactile image in the video]
Bookend: [same location/object, open and close, same camera position]
Match-cut chain: [object -> object -> object]
Impact words: [WORD] · [WORD] · [WORD]

| Beat | Shot |
|---|---|
| | |

### PACKAGING
```

Titles

- 1.
- 2.
- 3.

Description

> [What the video argues.]
>
> Sources: [...]. Not financial advice. Educational only.

Hashtags:

Pinned comment

> [The caveat that did not fit, or the objection you know is coming.]

~~###~~ COMPLIANCE

On-screen 0:00-0:04: "Educational only. Not financial advice."

APPENDIX B

PRODUCTION FILE TEMPLATE

Save as `PRODUCTION.md`. Write it during production.

```
# Production Record – [VIDEO]

### FINAL VIDEO
- Watch:      [url]
- video_id:   [id]
- Session:    [revisable session url]
- Duration:   [__]s · 9:16 · [resolution]

### Build settings
- Style:      [name] – [id]
- Voice:      [name] – [id]
- Mode:       [revisable | fire-and-forget]
- Orientation: portrait

### Verification – [WATCHED | COMPLETE, NOT VERIFIED]

| Check | Result | Evidence |
|---|---|---|
| Narration verbatim | | |
| No faces / identifiable people | | |
| Imagery is the base layer | | |
| Palette held | | |
| Captions burned in and legible | | |
| No real logos | | |
| Footnotes present | | |
| Compliance card in first 4s | | |
| Cut rhythm under 2s | | |
| Close is the scripted close | | |

Pass / Fail / Unknown. Unknown is not Fail – record what you could not check.

### Constraints hit
- [what was blocked, exhausted or unavailable]
- [what it cost the work]

### Workarounds used
- [what was done instead]
- [what it cost – always fill this in]

### Superseded renders
- [id] – [why it was superseded]

### Credits
- Balance at session start: [__] · resets [date]
```

APPENDIX C

THE BRIEF TEMPLATE

Paste whole. Fill the bracketed fields. Do not trim the constraint blocks — they are the parts that go missing.

Create a ~[___]-second vertical (9:16) short for a FACELESS channel.

CRITICAL: NO avatar, NO presenter, NO human face anywhere. Voiceover only.
Use this narration script VERBATIM — do not rewrite, shorten, or add to it:
"[SCRIPT]"

LAYER STACK — imagery-first, three layers:

1. BASE — cinematic photographic imagery filling the frame, the foundation of every scene. Never a texture or an abstract background.
2. MID — motion graphics over that imagery: diagrams, counters, charts, name-tag grids.
3. TOP — hero typography and burned-in word-by-word captions, current word highlighted.

IMAGERY BY BEAT:

[beat] -> [concrete shot]

[beat] -> [concrete shot]

HERO SHOT: [the single most tactile image; name the beat it lands on]

BOOKEND: open on [X]; close on the SAME [X], changed, from the SAME camera position.

MATCH-CUT CHAIN: [object] -> [object] -> [object]

MOTION: Treat scenes as 3D space — push the camera THROUGH elements, hard parallax between layers, foreground streaking past the lens. Hero words scale past frame edges; letters arrive individually with overshoot; 1-2 frame white flash and screen shake on the biggest landings. No plain cuts — match-cut morphs, type-as-mask reveals, whip transitions with motion blur. Numbers count up physically; charts draw themselves then crack and drop on negative beats. Continuous motion in every frame; speed ramps into key words. Cut or punch in every 1.2-1.8s, no shot past 2s. A longer runtime means MORE cuts, not slower ones.

LOOK: Strict three-colour palette — near-black, white, one red accent. Grade imagery dark and desaturated; reserve red for graphics and type. Captions legible at all times — dark scrim behind text over busy plates.

HARD CONSTRAINTS: No human faces or identifiable people. No real corporate logos or mastheads — plain text name-tags only. No neon, gradients, sparkles, emoji, subscribe animations or clickbait arrows. Show "Educational only. Not financial advice." in the first 4 seconds.

TONE: Dry, confident, analytical newsroom. Cinematic, not a commercial. A neutral explainer that includes the negative data, not a promo.

```
Settings: mode [revisable], orientation portrait,  
style [ID], voice [ID].
```

AT THE APPROVAL STEP

Restate, in full sentences: the grade, the bookend, the hero shot, the cut rhythm, and the negative constraints. Read the plan for what it did *not* mention. Then approve — and do not reopen the script.

APPENDIX D

IDENTITY LOCK WORKSHEET

Fill once. Save as `IDENTITY.md`. Treat as read-only — changes get a version number and a commit message.

1 — LAYER STACK

Base layer, literally. What sits over it.

2 — PALETTE

Three colours max. Which is the accent, and what is it reserved for.

3 — GRADE

How photography is treated so it does not read as stock.

4 — TYPE AND CAPTIONS

Typeface class, caption style, position, scrim rule.

5 — MOTION RULES

Camera, transitions, data behaviour, cut rhythm in seconds.

6 — BAN LIST

Specific enough to check against a finished render.

7 — HARD CONSTRAINTS

Faces, logos, likeness, anything legal or structural.

8 — TONE

Three adjectives and one anti-pattern: “never a ___”.

9 — COMPLIANCE CARD

Exact wording, exact timing, every video.

10 — FIXED SETTINGS

Style ID, voice ID, mode, orientation.

VERSION

Number and date. Increment deliberately.

APPENDIX E

CONFIDENCE SCALE — QUICK CARD

LEVEL	MEANS	WHAT THE SCRIPT MAY DO
High	Primary source, or several independent sources that agree	State it plainly
Medium-high	Widely reported; primary source not read directly	State it plainly; put the source in the description
Medium	A single secondary source, or a range being summarised	Hedge in the wording: “about”, “over”, “roughly”
Estimate	An analyst projection or model output	Name whose estimate it is, on screen. Never speak it as a price
Unsourced	Cannot be traced to any original	Do not assert it. Flag it in the script itself

THE THREE-LAYER CORRECTION

LAYER	CARRIES
Narration	The hedge, in the sentence itself: “has valued... as high as”
On screen	The attribution, as a small footnote at that timecode
Pinned comment	The full range, including the conservative case

ROUNDING

Always round toward the weaker version of your own argument. “Over a hundred thousand” for 128,000. “About twenty pounds” for a cited range of 15 to 30. Credibility leaks out of a script one convenient rounding at a time.

THE TWO QUESTIONS THAT CATCH MOST ERRORS

1. Is this an approval date, an effective date, or a compliance deadline? They are three different dates and they are routinely conflated.
2. Is this a price, or somebody’s estimate of a value? If it is an estimate, whose?

APPENDIX F

SOURCES AND VERIFICATION LOG

Part Four asks you to record every external claim with a confidence level. It would be strange to sell you that discipline and not practise it. Every external fact in this book is below, with what it rests on.

METHOD AND ITS LIMITS

All external claims were checked on **22 September 2026**. Two of the relevant primary domains — YouTube’s help centre and YouTube’s official blog — were unreachable from the machine this edition was compiled on, because of a network egress policy. Where a row depends on those, it is marked *Medium* and says so. That is the honest state of the evidence, and it is exactly the situation Chapter 12 describes: a claim that is widely and consistently reported but whose primary source you have not read yourself is not the same as one you have.

CLAIM	RESTS ON	CONFIDENCE
YPP: 1,000 subscribers and either 4,000 watch hours / 12 months or 10 million Shorts views / 90 days; fan-funding tier at 500 subscribers, 3 uploads / 90 days, 3,000 hours or 3 million Shorts views; the two routes never combine; no active strikes	Multiple independent creator-industry sources in agreement, September 2026. YouTube's own help page could not be opened from this machine	Medium-high
From 1 Feb 2027: new applicants need 8,000 watch hours or 20 million Shorts views; existing members grandfathered; a 10 million Shorts views / 90 days floor for Shorts revenue sharing, restored automatically	Secondary reporting of a YouTube announcement, consistent across several outlets. Neither the announcement nor the help page was reachable from this machine	Medium — confirm before planning
“Repetitious content” policy renamed “inauthentic content” on 15 July 2025, clarified to cover mass-produced and repetitive content; not a new prohibition; enforcement described as moving to channel level	Trade press reporting of the policy update and subsequent policy trackers	Medium-high
Shorts may run up to 3 minutes; the limit rose from 60 seconds on 15 October 2024	Consistent across many independent sources; uncontested	High
Disclosure is required for realistic altered or synthetic content; production assistance and clearly unrealistic material generally exempt; repeated non-disclosure carries removal and monetization penalties	YouTube's announcement of the disclosure tool and help-centre summaries reported by several outlets	Medium-high
SEC approved amendments to FINRA Rule 4210 on 14 April 2026; effective 4 June 2026; the pattern day trader designation, day-trade counting and the \$25,000 minimum equity requirement eliminated; replaced by an	FINRA regulatory notice and investor guidance, the SEC release on the rule filing, and broker-dealer client notices — all in agreement	High

intraday margin standard; 18-month phase-in ending 20 October 2027

The \$2,000 figure is the long-standing minimum to open a margin account, unchanged by the amendments, and is not a new day-trading floor	As above	High
The “1894 London newspaper / nine feet of manure in fifty years” prediction cannot be sourced; it traces to a 2004 essay, and the attribution was refuted in 2018	The newspaper’s own later correction, plus repeated unsuccessful attempts by others to locate the original	Medium-high
Worked examples in Chapters 4, 8, 9, 12 and 14: charging-standard adoption, network valuation estimates, EV market share, energy storage revenue, horse populations, Model T production	Reproduced from the channel’s own fact tables, with the confidence levels and dates recorded there. They illustrate a method; they were not re-verified for this edition and must not be treated as current data	As originally recorded
All production incidents, runtimes, word counts, credit balances, failure modes and verification results	First-hand production records of the channel described	High

READ THIS TABLE THE WAY THE BOOK ASKS YOU TO READ YOURS

Two rows are Medium, and they are the two that concern your income. That is not a comfortable place for them to be, and pretending otherwise would have been easy and invisible. Go and check them at the platform’s own pages before you make a plan that depends on them — which is, in one sentence, the entire argument of Part Four.

LICENCE

Plain-language terms. They are meant to be generous about the work and strict about the document.

WHAT YOU MAY DO

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COLOPHON

Compiled from the production record of a faceless finance short-form channel: its script files, its style guide, its verification checklists, and the notes it kept on what broke.

Set in Oswald, Source Serif 4 and IBM Plex Mono. Typeset as HTML and rendered to PDF; the source document and its build script are kept in the same repository as the videos it describes, so that a correction is a commit rather than a new file.

Corrections and disagreements are welcome and will be credited in the next edition. If a figure in here is wrong, that is a defect in the thing this book is about, and it should be fixed in public.